

Talent is widely distributed, but opportunity often depends on access to information, resources, mentors, and professional networks. My educational journey from Nigeria to doctoral study in the United States has made this especially meaningful to me because scholarships, teachers, mentors, and academic communities helped make each next step visible. Those experiences shaped my commitment to students whose potential may be strong even when their access to educational resources or familiarity with academic systems is limited. I view inclusive excellence as creating an environment in which students can see a pathway into engineering and research, understand how to move forward, and receive the support needed to develop into independent scholars and professionals.

Making opportunity visible. Much of my commitment to inclusion has centered on sharing knowledge that can otherwise remain inaccessible to students without established academic networks. Before beginning my Ph.D., I volunteered as a Graduate Record Examination (GRE) instructor for prospective graduate students, teaching quantitative reasoning, verbal reasoning, analytical writing, test-taking strategies, and structured problem-solving. In 2021, EducationUSA Abuja invited me to share preparation strategies for the GRE and English proficiency examinations, and I returned as a resource person in 2024. I continue to share preparation materials and graduate application resources because timely access to reliable information can change not only how students prepare, but also which opportunities they believe are attainable. My earlier community outreach reflects the same principle. Through Junior Achievement Nigeria, I helped secondary school students learn about entrepreneurship, while a Google Road Show initiative allowed me to support school students in developing practical knowledge of internet use and online safety. These experiences taught me that outreach is most valuable when students leave with information or skills they can immediately use. As a faculty member, I plan to continue this work through research exposure activities, graduate school preparation workshops, and open resources that help students from backgrounds with fewer educational opportunities see clear pathways into engineering and advanced study.

Expanding access to research. Research can be one of the most transformative experiences in a student's education, yet access is often constrained by prior experience, finances, schedules, transportation, or institutional location. My research in scientific machine learning, uncertainty quantification, inverse modeling, manufacturing analytics, and image-based engineering creates opportunities to lower some of these barriers without lowering technical expectations. Many meaningful projects can begin with open datasets, documented code, simulation, image analysis, or reproducible computational notebooks before requiring specialized laboratory access. In my future research group, I plan to create well-scoped entry projects that connect students to larger questions in manufacturing, materials, thermal systems, and scientific machine learning. A student might begin by reproducing a benchmark, analyzing uncertainty in an existing model, evaluating a surrogate, or processing image data, then progress toward increasingly independent research questions. Remote and hybrid participation can provide additional entry points for students whose circumstances make traditional laboratory schedules difficult. My experience mentoring an international undergraduate researcher through ASU's Summer Research Initiative reinforced the value of giving students a manageable starting point, regular feedback, and a visible path toward greater intellectual ownership.

Building an inclusive academic community. Inclusive mentoring means more than inviting students into a group. It requires making expectations clear, distributing meaningful opportunities fairly, and ensuring that students are not confined to less visible roles because of their initial confidence or experience. I aim to create research teams in which students understand how decisions are made, receive specific and constructive feedback, and progressively take responsibility for literature synthesis, methodological choices, validation, interpretation, and communication. When participation patterns suggest that some students are consistently less engaged or receiving fewer opportunities to contribute technically, I view that as information about the environment I have helped create and an invitation to improve it. As a faculty member, I will combine transparent mentoring, accessible research pathways, community outreach, and resource sharing to help students from varied backgrounds participate fully in academic life. My goal is not to reduce rigor, but to reduce unnecessary barriers around access to that rigor. I want students whose

starting points differ from my own or from one another to be able to see how to enter, how to grow, and how to contribute meaningfully. The opportunities that once helped make my own academic path visible are the same kinds of opportunities I hope to make more visible for others.